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ARTICLE

Russia's Plague Mystery: What Are The World's Labs Creating?



BY PNW STAFF OCTOBER 07, 2026

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Something strange happened at a Russian laboratory that studies some of the most dangerous pathogens on Earth.



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Twenty-eight-year-old Darya Shipilova, an employee of the Irkutsk Anti-Plague Research Institute in Siberia, became seriously ill and died October 2 from what Russian authorities describe as pneumonia of unknown origin. Reports circulated that she may have been exposed to pneumonic plague in a laboratory accident, although Russian officials deny that account and say testing found no pathogen connected to her work.

Nearly 200 contacts were initially placed under medical observation or isolation. Most have since been released, Russia says no plague has been detected, and the World Health Organization currently considers the broader public-health risk very low.

Perhaps that will ultimately be the end of the story.

But the incident has opened the door to a much larger question that received far less attention during the COVID pandemic and deserves considerably more today:

What exactly are laboratories around the world doing with the deadliest pathogens known to mankind?

The Diseases We Don't Talk About

COVID was devastating, but biologically speaking, it was nowhere near the worst pandemic scenario imaginable.

The World Health Organization maintains a list of pathogens considered priorities because of their epidemic potential and the limited countermeasures available against them. It includes Ebola and Marburg, Nipah virus, Lassa fever, MERS and SARS, Crimean-Congo hemorrhagic fever and something ominously called "Disease X" -- WHO's placeholder for a currently unknown pathogen capable of causing a serious international epidemic.

Consider Nipah virus. Some outbreaks have produced extraordinarily high fatality rates. Fortunately, Nipah has never developed anything approaching COVID's ability to sweep efficiently through human populations.

And therein lies the nightmare.

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Imagine a disease considerably more lethal than COVID that also possesses COVID-like transmissibility.

Add another characteristic: symptoms that don't appear immediately, allowing infected people to travel and spread it before realizing they are sick.

Then add resistance to existing treatments.

That is the sort of combination that could transform a disease outbreak into a civilization-level emergency.



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Why Are We Studying These Things?

There is an important answer to that question: because we need to.

Scientists cannot easily develop vaccines, diagnostic tests and treatments against dangerous diseases without studying the organisms responsible for them. Laboratories also monitor mutations, identify emerging threats and give health authorities a chance to recognize outbreaks before they become pandemics.

The problem is something scientists call "dual-use research."

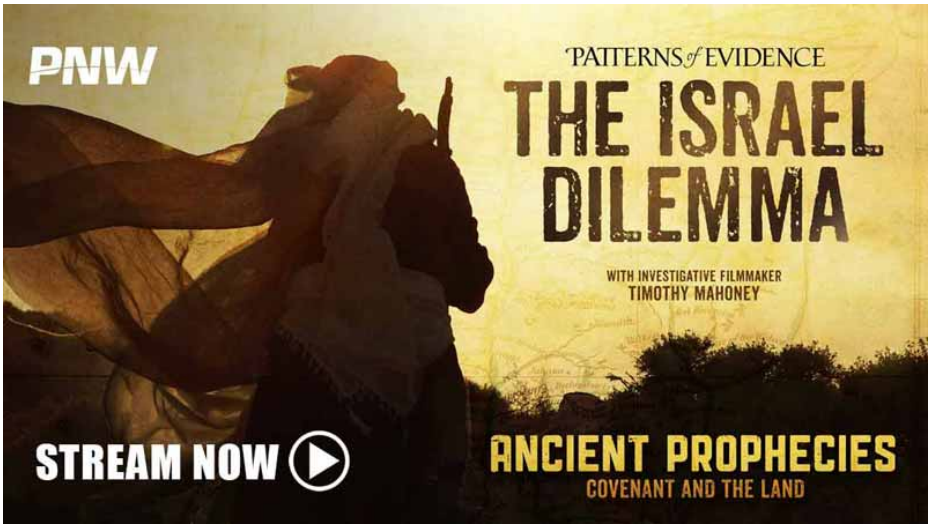
The same knowledge that teaches us how to stop a pathogen can potentially teach someone how to make it more dangerous.

Research might examine what allows a virus to infect new species, evade immunity, become resistant to treatment or spread more efficiently. Such experiments can have legitimate scientific purposes. They can also create obvious risks.

Those concerns became serious enough that President Trump issued an executive order in 2025 restricting federal support for what the administration defines as dangerous gain-of-function research -- experiments capable of increasing characteristics such as pathogenicity, transmissibility, drug resistance or the ability to evade detection.

Even WHO acknowledges the changing danger. Its updated laboratory biosecurity guidance specifically addresses risks arising from genetic modification and manipulation of pathogens as well as artificial intelligence. The purpose is not simply to prevent laboratory accidents, but also theft and deliberate misuse.

That should get our attention.



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Biological Weapons Didn't Disappear

Russia makes the present controversy particularly troubling because this is not theoretical history.

The Soviet Union operated an enormous secret biological-weapons program despite signing the Biological Weapons Convention. American assessments have concluded that Russia inherited significant portions of that apparatus rather than completely dismantling it.

A U.S. State Department compliance assessment concluded that the Soviet biological-weapons program was "absorbed, not dismantled" and that it "continued and evolved" under the Russian Federation.

That does not prove Shipilova's death had anything to do with biological weapons. There is currently no evidence establishing such a connection.

But it explains why the world is paying attention.

Former Soviet biological-weapons officials have described experiments involving plague and efforts to develop antibiotic-resistant pathogens. If antibiotics are one of humanity's principal defenses against bacterial diseases, deliberately engineering around that defense changes the equation dramatically.

And Russia is hardly the only reason for concern.

America's 2026 intelligence threat assessment warns that advances in synthetic biology, bioinformatics, nanotechnology and genome editing could produce novel biological threats while simultaneously increasing the possibility of accidental pathogen releases.

Technology is changing what is possible.

When Biology Meets Artificial Intelligence

This may eventually become the most important part of the story.

Building a sophisticated biological weapon once required the resources of governments, enormous laboratories and armies of highly trained scientists.

But biotechnology is advancing at breathtaking speed.

Scientists can manipulate genomes with increasing precision. DNA can be synthesized. Computer systems can analyze enormous biological datasets. Artificial intelligence is increasingly capable of helping researchers understand proteins, molecules and biological processes that once required years of work.

These technologies offer enormous benefits. They could help cure diseases, develop medicines and stop future pandemics.

But every technological revolution has a darker side.

The concern is not that an AI system will suddenly manufacture a pandemic by itself. It is that tools that dramatically accelerate legitimate biological discovery may also gradually lower the knowledge barriers that once kept extremely sophisticated biological manipulation beyond the reach of most people.

The distance between "What can governments do?" and "What can a small group do?" could continue shrinking.

COVID Was A Warning

The lesson from COVID should not simply be that another coronavirus might emerge.

It should be that modern civilization is extraordinarily vulnerable to infectious disease.

Within weeks, borders closed. Churches shut their doors. Schools emptied. International travel collapsed. Businesses disappeared. Governments assumed emergency powers. Supply chains buckled. Fear swept across continents almost as quickly as the virus itself.

And that was not the worst pathogen nature -- or potentially mankind -- could produce.

That is what makes the mystery in Siberia worth watching even if Russia's explanation proves completely correct.

The real story isn't necessarily what happened inside one Russian laboratory.

It is what is happening inside laboratories everywhere as humanity gains increasingly powerful tools to manipulate life itself.

There are good reasons to study dangerous diseases. There are scientists doing that work precisely because they want to prevent the next pandemic.

But the stakes are becoming enormous.

One mistake, one security failure, one reckless experiment or one malicious actor could potentially unleash something that cannot simply be recalled once it leaves the laboratory.

For Christians, Scripture's repeated warnings about pestilence no longer describe something belonging only to the ancient world. Our generation has already witnessed how quickly disease can shake the entire planet.

COVID demonstrated what a pandemic can do.

The more unsettling question is what happens when the next pathogen is worse.

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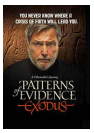
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